

Ubuntu is an extremely popular and user-friendly operating system that comes with an aesthetically impressive interface and is backed by a large community of fellow Ubuntu users worldwide. With over 20 million users, Ubuntu has a rightful claim as the world's most loved free operating system.

In fact, Ubuntu is much more than just a Linux distro. It is gradually evolving and venturing into newer markets and niches, such as solutions for smartphones and tablets, among many others. Quite obviously, if there is one Linux distro that deserves to be ranked above the rest, it has to be Ubuntu!

Ubuntu comes with its own desktop environment, which is called Unity. However, there are other variants available as well, such as Kubuntu for KDE and Xubuntu for XFCE.

Website: www.ubuntu.com

2. Linux Mint

Linux Mint stands on the shoulders of giants because it is based on Ubuntu, which in turn is based on Debian. To be fair, Linux Mint basically began as a project to fix or amend certain usability issues in Ubuntu, but over a short period of time, it gained a good momentum and according to DistroWatch, it currently stands right behind Ubuntu in terms of users (and possibly is abreast with Fedora and/or openSUSE).

Considering the fact that Linux Mint traces its ancestry back to Debian and Ubuntu, it makes good use of the official repositories and update channels, providing its users with a plethora of updated software and tools to choose from.

Linux Mint natively comes with a remixed desktop environment of its own, commonly called Cinnamon. KDE, GNOME, LXDE and other versions are available as well. However, the USP of Linux Mint is that it was one of the earliest distros to offer certain key elements out of the box (such as multimedia codecs), which helped this distro attract new audiences and build a strong community.

Website: www.linuxmint.com

3. Fedora

Moving on from the .DEB family to the .RPM family, we have Fedora that is ranked third on our list.

Fedora is often termed as the testing ground for Red Hat Enterprise Linux. That said, Fedora's distinction is that it is one of the most cutting-edge Linux distros meant for general usage. It is based on a rough six-month release cycle and owing to this terrific update frequency, Fedora often ends up incorporating and making use of newer software and updated tools way before any other distro.

Fedora is also one of the premier and flagship distributions that ship with GNOME (of course, other desktop environments can also be installed).

Website: <http://www.fedoraproject.org/>

4. openSUSE

openSUSE is a general-purpose Linux distribution that offers a good variety of options when it comes to selecting your desktop environment and other specifics. However, right from its inception, openSUSE has not enjoyed much neutrality from the Linux community for some reason or the other. Apparently, openSUSE is either passionately loved or extremely hated by Linux users.

Generally, openSUSE follows an eight-month release cycle. Besides, it also serves as the base for SUSE Linux Enterprise. All in all, openSUSE is a highly polished and versatile Linux distribution that you should surely give a spin, if you have not done so already.

Website: <http://www.opensuse.org/>

5. PCLinuxOS

PCLinuxOS is probably a questionable entry to wind up this list (ahead of the likes of Gentoo and Slackware), but the fact that it is one of the most popular among all the distros that trace their lineage to Mandrake Linux earns it the #5 spot.

PCLinuxOS attempts to combine different and diverse technologies in order to create a worthy computing experience for lovers of open source. It is one of those few distributions that can be used by both newbies and advanced users alike. Plus, even though it is an independent project in its own right, PCLinuxOS maintains many elements from Mandrake Linux.

While PCLinuxOS is definitely a Linux distro worthy of respect and appreciation, its community and user base is not as large as that of Ubuntu or Fedora. Beyond that, though, it definitely packs a punch and provides all the functionality that is required from a full-fledged Linux distribution.

Website: <http://www.pclinuxos.com/>

With that, we come to the end of this roundup of the top five Linux distros. Once again, considering the fact that open source is about appreciating and acknowledging the power of freedom, what are your picks when it comes to the top five Linux distributions? Does your list seem to overlap with mine or not at all? Do write in and share your thoughts! 

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